or the I2U2 and initiatives like the ISA. The China challenge can only be countered by reversing past neglect of the border infrastructure and maintaining deployments and, indeed, by utilizing the possibilities that global dynamics can offer. On the economic front, we have to be judicious in picking the FTAs and frameworks that truly serve our interests. The need to refresh both analysis and policy will only increase in a turbulent world.

CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

For any polity, national security has an undeniable primacy. Indians are much more conscious of this than most since it has been challenged so often in the last 75 years. In fact, when we evaluate the merits of leadership, it is largely perceived as a mix of addressing crises and ensuring delivery. A lot of our foreign policy is devoted to preparing for, obviating, mitigating and reacting to security threats. Clearly, a time has come that we must decisively address longstanding vulnerabilities that a competitive world regularly exploits. It may have been a political surprise in August 2019 that the Article 370 issue was firmly settled. But the fact is that mainstreaming Jammu & Kashmir was long overdue, and only vested interests were standing in the way.

We need to equally apply ourselves to the hard task of securing our borders effectively, including through promotion of Vibrant Villages Programme. At the same time, as the world penetrates into our daily existence more prominently, we must develop awareness and responses to the problems posed by the ‘normal’. These are dangers emanating from the routine, be it digital, financial, ideological or even mobility-related. Just as international economics is grappling with the challenges of new practices, national security, too, must address more contemporary dangers.

A foreign policy that impinges so many aspects of our life understandably has deeper personal implications on our safety, welfare, prospects and opportunities. It has transactional and collaborative connotations, especially in the economic and technology domains. There are, of course, threads of continuity that run parallel to the compulsions of change. As always, foreign policy is a constant exercise of building power and exercising influence, whether for national or collective purpose. It can be a competition of ideas, values or culture that combine to set forth a vision of our future. Each of these facets, old and new, co-exist with others